
“This Big Shot Is The Hottest Toy In America: 2 Million Kids Are Packing This Squirt Gun, And The Rest Are Jealous”

July 28, 1991|By Mike Capuzzo, Knight-Ridder Tribune News | Chicago Tribune

Please also watch Business Insider video ([link here](#))

PHILADELPHIA — The call came to the old brick warehouse on Callowhill Street, home of the most powerful toy water gun in world history: the Super Soaker 100. Al Davis, executive vice president of Larami Corp., picked up the phone. It was a grandmother calling from western Pennsylvania. A sweet, loving granny who wanted to buy what may be the hottest-and coolest-toy in the U.S. for her grandson.

And she wanted to punch Al Davis in the kisser. “I’d like to slap you and wipe that grin off your face!” she shouted. “I’ve been looking for a Super Soaker for three weeks!”



Davis is the Philadelphia toymaker America loves to hate. He manufactures the Buck Rogers-style, neon-colored plastic water gun that squirts an absurd distance-up to 55 feet-and that parents will go to absurd lengths to buy.

John Lancaster, owner of Discount Harry’s in Pennsauken, Pa., one of the region’s largest toy stores, found 25 parents waiting for him to open the door one recent morning to buy what he calls the “hottest-selling seasonal toy I’ve ever seen. Hotter than the Cabbage Patch doll (in 1983). Hotter than the Pac-Man (game cartridge) 10 years ago.”

Mike Bertic, advertising manager of the Midwest office of Toys “R” Us, in Joliet, said that in the Chicago area: “As soon as we get them in, they’re gone. They’re gone in a day. Who knows how many we could have sold if we could have met the demand. It just took off.” He added, however, “It’s not as chaotic as the Cabbage Patch was. I don’t think there’ll ever be anything like that again.”

Its appeal? “It’s different. It does something no other squirt gun has done before,” Bertic said. “And it’s cool-looking, too, you know.” Asked if the hot weather might have fueled sales, Bertic said: “I don’t think that had anything to do with it. It still would have sold.”

One mother in the Northeast drove to 10 stores before finally finding a Soaker. It wasn’t the model her 8-year-old son wanted, but the clerk warned: “You’d better buy one. There’s only two left, and we’ve only had them for a couple of hours.” She did.

A store manager in Deptford, Pa., tired of being hassled by parents, put up a sign: “We’re out of Super Soakers and we don’t expect any more in.” In Passaic, N.J., two fathers almost duked it out over one remaining Super Soaker before store employees separated them.

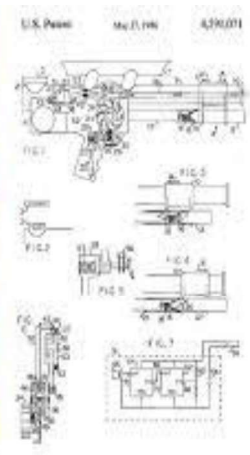
The Super Soaker is part toy, part cultural phenomenon. More than 2 million have been sold in the 50 states and thousands more in Japan, Mexico, Canada and Chile, most since March. Johnny Carson did a Super Soaker monologue.

You see them at pools, beaches, lakes, wherever children and water meet. Suburban kids drench their dogs and cats; city kids get cool in the soaking spray. Bertic at Toys “R” Us speculated, “I would bet money on it that frat houses buy them too.” If they can find one.



What went wrong, Al? "We thought we'd have a hit," Davis said sheepishly. "But we never imagined it would be like this. What was I supposed to do, make 24 million of them?" That'd be a start. There are 24 million children in the U.S., not to mention the foreign markets.

An engineer's doodlings: The Super Soaker began where many wacky inventions begin: in California. The inventor is Lonnie Johnson, 41, an engineer with the Jet Propulsion Lab in Pasadena, Calif. Rather, a former engineer. He quit his job in January, shortly after the Super Soaker hit the market. Larami expects to sell as many as 4 million squirt guns-at \$7 to \$30 retail-and Johnson gets a royalty for each.



Johnson now spends his days at home in Altadena, caring for his two young sons and working on more serious inventions, including a home radon detector. Two years ago, he brought his odd-looking, mega-water-pistol prototype to the toy industry's big national fair in New York, looking for a manufacturer. The toy operates on a simple principle: Put a lot of water into a reservoir atop the gun (about a quart in the mid-size Super Soaker 50; a half-gallon in the 100). Pressurize the water with a pump that works like a bicycle-tire pump. Then fire-about twice as far as many battery-operated models, such as the former state-of-the-squirt Larami X-Ray Gun featured in the film "Don't Tell Mom the Babysitter's Dead."

Two toy-industry giants turned down Johnson's idea. But at the toy fair, Davis invited Johnson to Philadelphia for a demonstration, then signed him up on the spot. "I could sit here and say I was brilliant," Davis said, "but it was a simple thing, really. I liked it and I thought kids would like it." The prototype, however, was "too sophisticated, too elaborate for the toy trade," Davis said. "It had all kinds of different valves. We would have had to sell it for \$40. I wanted a \$10 toy. I felt, at \$10, every kid would want one."

Using Johnson's patented air-pressure idea, Bruce D'Andre, a Larami engineer, designed a simpler plastic toy. Two patents cover the Super Soaker, with four more pending. "The beauty of it is, once you pressurize it, you don't have to repressurize it," Davis said. "That's one of the secrets of the Super Soaker."

Back-yard battles: After a false start under the name Drencher, the toy was tried out in Ohio under the Super Soaker label. Ninety children, 9 to 11, were shown a film touting the gun. Davis was astonished with the results.

"Every kid got the two most important messages right away. One, it holds a lot of water. Two, it shoots a lot of water far." Ninety children's voices cried out in unison. "They all wanted one-without exception."

Then, in December 1990, just before Christmas, Larami got some priceless publicity: Carson sprayed his audience and joked with Ed McMahon about holding up a retirement home: "Give me your money or I'll soak you."

In March, the company got another big break: unseasonably warm weather that continued into May, just as Larami's nationwide TV ads kicked in. Larami's ads represented the first national campaign in the mid-size toy



company's 33-year history, an investment of almost \$1 million. The commercials, with a revenge-of-the-nerds theme, were seen in 20 major markets from April 29 until June 3.

Before long, "one kid on the block got it, and the other kids had to have it, because if they were going to have a water battle, they were going to lose unless they had a Super Soaker," Davis said.

Jonathan Barchi, 9, of Lower Merion, got a Super Soaker 100 a couple of months ago as a present from his parents for getting a good report card. It's blue, a much-desired color his best friend couldn't find anywhere, even after his parents searched a dozen stores.

Now his best friend has a less-powerful Super Soaker 50, but Jonathan takes on all makes and models in half-hour water fights in his back yard. "I just don't pressurize it as much, so I don't have so much of an advantage," he said.

Flooding the market: With thousands of testimonials, Davis cranked up the manufacturers in China and Macau to churn out hundreds of thousands more Super Soakers.

At Discount Harry's, Lancaster was seeking to reassure his customers. After selling 2,800 Soakers in 10 days, he paid the air freight from California for 2,100 more. "Sorry for the inconvenience caused due to not having the Super Soaker in stock," his sign said. "Merchandise will be delivered on or about June 30."

Davis says not to blame him. He sells to Woolworth's, for example, but the chain decides how many to distribute to each of its thousand stores. And don't call him, either. He doesn't know where you can buy one.

Besides, he's thinking of other things. In Harrisburg, Pa., where he made plans to sell Super Soakers to military bases worldwide, and where he talked about flooding spring break in San Diego next year, and where he mused over TV ads for England, France, Germany and Italy, Davis recently gave a quick peek at a new idea, then slammed his briefcase shut.

The Super Soaker 200. Better not print that," he said. "Everyone will want one. And we're not ready yet."

